

Topic 3: 19th Century Philippines

List of Reading Materials:

- **A Visit to the Philippine Islands**
- ***State of the Philippines in 1810* in The Former Philippines Thru Foreign Eyes**
- **Marcelo H. Del Pilar's Aba Guinoong Baria**
- ***The Philippine Islands* in La Solidaridad, Vol. 2: 1890**
- **Internal Political Condition of the Philippines in Emma Blair and James Robertson (eds.), The Philippine Islands**
- ***Our aims* in La Solidaridad**
- **"The Causes of the Distress of the Philippines"**
- **Album De Filipinas**

Introduction for 19th Century Philippines

The nineteenth century was a period of profound change for the Philippines. The abolition of the galleon trade in 1815 and the establishment of an export-oriented, cash crop economy led to important economic, political, and socio-cultural transformations that immensely affected the colony. For example, owing to the Philippines' engagement in the international market, economic opportunities were no longer limited to certain privileged sectors from the government and the church. Some groups of *indios naturales* had also benefitted from these developments, which, led to their upward socio-economic mobility. They became the "middle class," who, through their recently-acquired wealth, was able to send their children to Europe to study. Economic development in society, however, was uneven. The majority of the population, mostly belonging to the laboring classes, still lived in material deprivation, and oftentimes found it difficult to fulfil their pecuniary obligations to the state. These and other related events contributed to the formation of reformist and revolutionary organizations which played a crucial role in ending the Spanish control of the islands in 1898.

The set of materials included here presents the various facets of colonial life in the nineteenth century Philippines. These were written by various Spanish officials and administrators, Filipino propagandists, and foreign travelers and observers. Presented either in their entirety or a portion from the original texts, these source materials provide a glimpse into the conditions and changes occurring in the colony at that time. Some of them highlight what reforms, projects and programs were needed to secure progress in the Philippines. Others emphasize what could happen if these measures were implemented or when things were left as they were. Ultimately, the collection will help the readers understand and appreciate the "long" nineteenth century as an important period in the history of the country.

Bowring, John. 1859. *A Visit to the Philippine Islands*. London: Smith, Elder & Co, 202-212.

The Author and His Work

A Visit to the Philippine Islands is an account written by Sir John Bowring about his brief sojourn to the Philippines in 1858, while mourning the recent loss of his wife. Bowring, who served as British Consul at Canton (1849) and, later, governor of Hong Kong (1854-1859), wrote about his official travel to the Spanish colony in 1859, and published it in the same year. His seven-week tour on the steam-powered paddle frigate *Magicienne* covered several areas which included Manila, Laguna, and Tayabas. In *A Visit to the Philippines* (comprising 27 chapters in total), he presented an engaging narration of the political, economic, and socio-cultural life the Philippines from the time the Spaniards first set foot on the islands until the early decades of the nineteenth century. It is evident that in addition to his own insightful observations, he also used English and Spanish published materials to enrich his account. The particular text below, taken from the Chapter 12 (Ecclesiastical Authority) of the book, discusses the authority of the Church over the colonized populations, the sources and basis of this authority, and how it was liberally exercised by the different religious groups and congregations in the Philippines.

Text

It cannot be denied that, in the language of Tomas de Comyn,¹ “the missionaries were the real conquerors of the Philippines; their arms were not, indeed, those of the warrior, but they gave laws to millions, and, scattered though they were, they established by unity of purpose and of action a permanent empire over immense multitudes of men.” Up to the present hour there are probably few parishes in which the gobernadorcillo,² having received a mandate from the civil authority, fails to consult the friar, and the efficiency and activity of the Indian³ functionary in giving effect to the mandate will much depend on the views the padre may take of the orders issued.

The opulence of the individual monks, and of some of the monkish fraternities in the islands, has often and naturally been a subject of reproach. The revenues received by individuals are in many localities very large, amounting in remote districts to eight or nine thousand dollars a year, and much more, it is reported, in such populous pueblos⁴ as Binondo. Some of these communities also possess large tracts of land, whose management is superintended at periodical meetings held in the capital, when friars from the different provinces, and of the same brotherhood, are summoned to give an account of their stewardship, and to discuss the general interests of the

¹ referring to Tomas de Comyn who wrote *The State of the Philippines* in 1810.

² head of a town

³ or “indios naturales,” referring to the native inhabitants of the Philippines

⁴ pueblos or towns

fraternity. The accumulations of the friars pass to the convents at their death, but they have little difficulty in disposing of them while living.

It has been said that the policy of the friars in the Philippines is to conduct the Indian to heaven by a pathway of flowers. Little molestation will he experience from his ghostly father, if he be strict in his religious observances, pay his regular contributions to Church and State, and exhibit those outward marks of respect and reverence which the representatives of the Deity claim as their lawful heritage; but there are many thorns amidst the flowers, and drawbacks, on the heavenly road; and the time may come when higher and nobler aspirations than those which now satisfy the poor untutored, or little tutored, Indian, will be his rule of conduct.

The personal courtesies, the kind reception and multifarious attentions which I received from the friars in every part of the Philippines naturally dispose me to look upon them with a friendly eye. I found among them men worthy of being loved and honoured, some of considerable intellectual vigour; but literary cultivation and scientific acquirements are rare. Occupied with their own concerns, they are little acquainted with mundane affairs. Politics, geography, history, have no charms for those who, even had they the disposition for study, would, in their seclusion and remoteness, have access to few of its appliances. Their convents are almost palatial, with extensive courts, grounds and gardens; their revenues frequently enormous. Though their mode of life is generally unostentatious and simple, many of them keep handsome carriages and have the best horses in the locality; and they are surrounded generally by a prostrate and superstitious population, upon whose hopes and fears, thoughts and feelings, they exercise an influence which would seem magical were it not by their devotees deemed divine. This influence, no doubt, is greatly due to the heroism, labours, sufferings and sacrifices of the early missionaries, and to the admirably organized hierarchy of the Roman Church, whose ramifications reach to the extremest points in which any of the forms or semblances of Christianity are to be discovered. Volumes upon volumes—the folio records of the proceedings of the different religious orders, little known to Protestant readers—fill the library shelves of these Catholic establishments, which are the receptacles of their religious history.

A source of influence possessed by the friars, and from which a great majority of civil functionaries are excluded, is the mastery of the native languages. All the introductory studies of ecclesiastical aspirants are dedicated to this object. No doubt they have great advantages from living habitually among the Indian people, with whom they keep up the most uninterrupted intercourse, and of whose concerns they have an intimate knowledge. One of the most obvious means of increasing the power of the civil departments would be in encouragement given to their functionaries for the acquirement of the native idioms. I believe Spanish is not employed in the pulpits anywhere beyond the capital. In many of the pueblos there is not a single individual Indian who understands Castilian, so that the priest is often the only link between the government and the community, and, as society is now organized, a necessary link. It must be recollected, too, that the different members of the religious brotherhoods are bound together by stronger bonds and a more potent and influential organization than any official hierarchy among civilians; and the government can expect no co-operation from the priesthood in any measures which tend to the diminution of ecclesiastical authority or jurisdiction, and yet the subjection of that authority to the State, and its limitation wherever it interferes with the public well-being, is

the great necessity and the all-important problem to be solved in the Philippines. But here, too, the *Catholic* character of the government itself presents an enormous and almost invincible difficulty. Nothing is so dear to a Spaniard in general as his religion; his orthodoxy is his pride and glory, and upon this foundation the Romish Church naturally builds up a political power and is able to intertwine its pervading influence with all the machinery of the civil government.

Tomas de Comyn. [1810] 1917. *State of the Philippines in 1810*. In *The Former Philippines Thru Foreign Eyes*, edited by Austin Craig, pp. 357- 458. New York: D. Appleton and Company.

The *State of the Philippines in 1810*⁵ was written by Tomas de Comyn, who served, for several years, as general manager of the Royal Philippine Company, a chartered company established in 1785.⁶ Comyn had at least three main purposes in writing this text. First, to describe the political, economic, and socio-cultural aspects of Philippine life during the first decade of the nineteenth century. Second, to examine the pressing issues at the time, such as Moro attacks, corruption in the government, and ineptitude of public officials that, for him, impeded economic progress. Finally, to call public attention to the current state of the colony so that the government could devise a plan to advance the islands' development. His work did not evoke the attention he hoped to capture. However, it is still an important historical source as it presents a general overview of the Philippine condition a few years before the abolition of the galleon and the opening of the colony to international trade.⁷ The specific passage below deals with land ownership, as well as the various concerns related to it, and Comyn's view on how the state could remedy these issues.

Excerpt:

Estates. The proprietors of estates in the Philippines are of four classes. The most considerable is that of the religious orders, Augustinians and Dominicans, who cultivate their respective lands on joint account, or let them out at a moderate ground-rent, which the planters pay in kind; but far from living in opulence, and accumulating the immense revenues some of the religious communities enjoy in America,⁸ they stand in need of all they earn and possess for their maintenance, and in order to be enabled to discharge the various duties and obligations annexed to the missions with which they are entrusted.

Spanish planters. The second class comprehends the Spanish proprietors, whose number possibly does not exceed a dozen of persons, and even they labor under such disadvantages, and have to contend with so many obstacles, under the existing order of things, that, compelled to divide their lands into rice plantations, in consequence of this being the species of culture to

⁵ Tomas de Comyn. [1810] 1917. *State of the Philippines in 1810*. In *The Former Philippines Thru Foreign Eyes*, edited by Austin Craig, pp. 357-458. New York: D. Appleton and Company.

⁶ The Royal Philippine Company was granted a monopoly to import Chinese and Indian commodities into the Philippines as well as to transport goods from the colony directly to Spain.

⁷ The galleon trade—the economic lifeblood of the Philippines for more than two centuries—was officially abolished in 1815. A few years later, in 1834, the Philippines was opened to international trade.

⁸ Comyn was referring to the colonies of the Spanish Empire since the sixteenth century in central and southern America.

which the natives are most inclined, and to devote a considerable portion of them to the grazing of horned cattle, no one of them is in a situation to give to agriculture the variety and extent desired, or to attain any progress in a pursuit which in other colonies rapidly leads to riches.

Filipino⁹ farmers. The third consists of the principal mestizos and natives, and is in fact that which constitutes the real body of farming proprietors. In the fourth and last may be included all the other natives, who generally possess a small strip of land situated round their dwellings, or at the extremities of the various towns and settlements formed by the conquerors¹⁰; besides what they may have obtained from their ancestors in the way of legal inheritance, which rights have been confirmed to them by the present sovereign of the colony.

Aids to agriculture. It will beyond doubt, in some measure dissipate the distrust by which the Filipino is actuated, when the new and paternal exertions of the superior government, to ameliorate his present situation, are fully known, and when that valuable portion of our distant population is assured that their rights will henceforth be respected, and those exactions and compulsory levies which formerly so much disheartened them, are totally abolished. On the other hand, a new stimulus will be given by the living example and fresh impulse communicated to the provinces by other families emigrating and settling there, nurtured in the spirit and principles of those reforms in the ideas and maxims of government by which the present era is distinguished. A practical participation in these advantages will, most assuredly, awaken a spirit of enterprise and emulation that may be extremely beneficial to agriculture, and as the wants of the natives increase in proportion as they are enabled to know and compare the comforts arising out of the presence and extension of conveniences and luxuries in their own towns, they will naturally be led to possess and adopt them.

Plans for progress. So salutary a change, however, can only be the work of time, and as long as the government confines itself to a system merely protecting, the effects must consequently be slow. As it is therefore necessary to put in action more powerful springs than the ordinary ones, it will be found expedient partly to relax from some of those general principles which apply to societies, differently constituted, or rather formed of other perfectly distinct elements. As relating to the subject under discussion, I fortunately discover two means, pointed out in the laws themselves, essentially just, and at the same time capable of producing in this populous colony, more than in any other, the desired results. The legislator, founding himself on the common obligation of the subject to contribute something in return for the protection he receives, and to co-operate in the increase of the power and opulence of the State, proscribes idleness as a crime, and points out labor as a duty; and although the regulations touching the natives breathe the spirit of humanity, and exhibit the wisdom with which they were originally formed, they nevertheless concur and are directed to this primary object. In them the distribution of vacant lands, as well as of the natives at fair daily wages to clear them, is universally allowed, and these it seems to me,

⁹ During the nineteenth century, the term "Filipino" was used to refer to Philippine-born Spanish residents in the colony. In the 1880s, the Propagandists appropriated this term for themselves.

¹⁰ Comyn was referring to Spanish conquerors such as Miguel Lopez de Legazpi, who arrived in the Philippines in the sixteenth century.

are the means from an equitable and intelligent application of which the most beneficial consequences may be expected.

Confiscating unused lands. The first cannot be attended with any great difficulty, because all the provinces abound in waste and vacant lands, and scarcely is there a district in which some are not to be found of private property completely uncultivated and neglected, and consequently susceptible, as above stated, of being legally transferred, for this reason alone, to the possession of an active owner. Let their nature however, be what it may, in their adjudication, it is of the greatest importance to proceed with uniformity, by consecrating, in a most irrevocable manner, the solemnity of all similar grants. Public interest and reason, in the Philippine Islands, require that in all such cases deference only should be paid to demands justly interposed, and formally established within a due and fixed period; but after full and public notice has been given by the respective judicial authorities, of the titles about to be granted, the counter claims the natives may seek to put in after the lapse of the period prefixed, should be peremptorily disregarded. Although at first sight this appears a direct infringement on the imprescriptible rights of property, it must be considered that in some cases individual interests ought to be sacrificed to the general good, and that the balance used, when treating of the affairs of State, is never of that rigid kind as if applied to those of minor consideration. The fact is, that by this means many would be induced to form estates, who have hitherto been withheld by the dread of involving themselves, and spending their money in law suits; at the same time the natives, gradually accustoming themselves to this new order of things, would lay aside that disposition to strife and contention, which forms so peculiar a trait in their character, and that antipathy and odium would also disappear with which they have usually viewed the agricultural undertakings of Spaniards.

Del Pilar, Marcelo H. 1888. *La Frailocracia Filipina*, trans. Leonor Agrava, 33-43. Manila: National Historical Institute, 2009.

Marcelo H. del Pilar was born in Cupang, Bulacan on 30 August 1850 to Julian H. del Pilar and Blasa Gatmaitan. He first began schooling with a private tutor, Mr. Flores, and proceeded to study at the University of Santo Tomas where he obtained his bachelor's degree and law degree.

Early on, he became involved in anti-friar activities. He founded the *Diariong Tagalog* on 1 June 1882. Later, he led anti-friar movements in Malolos. Because of the fear of reprisal for his anti-friar activities, Del Pilar left the Philippines in 1889. He arrived in Spain and continued writing in *La Solidaridad*. From 1890 until the end of the newspaper's publication, Del Pilar served as its editor.

The following work by Del Pilar, “*La Frailocracia Filipina*,” was first published in Barcelona in 1889 and was written as a response to a pamphlet titled, “*Los Frailes en Filipinas*.” In this work, Del Pilar criticized the power of the friars in the country and called for radical reforms in the Philippines.

Del Pilar, Marcelo H. 1888. Aba Guinoong Baria. In Buhay at mga Sinulat ni Plaridad, ed. Jose P. Santos, 14. Maynila: Palimbag ng DALAGA.

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The following work by Del Pilar, "Aba Guinoong Baria," is a satire found in a collection called *Dasalan at Tocsohan*, which was said to have been co-written by Pedro Serrano Laktaw and Rafael Enriquez. The short poem, along with others like it in the collection, illustrates the avariciousness of friars in the Philippines. It drives home the point Del Pilar aimed to express: that the corruption of Philippine society can be blamed on the greed of the friars.

Excerpt :

Aba Guinoong Baria

Aba guinoong Baria nacapupuno ca nang alcancia ang Fraile'I sumasainyo bucod ca niyang pinagpala't pina higuít sa lahat, pinagpala naman ang caban mong ma-pasoc. Santa Baria Ina nang Deretsos, ipanalangin mo coming huag anitan ngayon at cami ipapatay. Siya naua.

Ang Aba Po Santa Baria

Aba po Santa Bariang Hari, inagao nang Fraile, icao ang cabuhayan at catamisan. Aba bunga nang aming pauis, icao ang pinagpaguran naming pinapanaw na tauong Anac ni Eva, icao nga ang ipinagbubuntong hininga naming sa aming pagtangis dito sa bayang pinacahapishapis. Ay aba pinacahanaphanap naming para sa aming manga anac, ilingon mo sa aming ang cara- i cruz mo man lamang at saca bago matapos ang pagpanaw mo sa amin ay iparinig mo sa amin ang iyong calasing Santa Baria ina nang deretsos, malacas at maalam, matunog na guinto cami ipanalangin mong huag magpatuloy sa aming ang manga banta nang Fraile. Amen.

Edmund Plauchut. 1877. The Philippine Islands. In *La Solidaridad*, Vol. 2: 1890, trans. Guadalupe Fores-Ganzon, 62-75. Pasig City: Fundación Santiago.

On the 20th year anniversary of the execution of the three priests, Jose Burgos, Mariano Gomez, and Jacinto Zamora, the newspaper *La Solidaridad* published Edmund Plauchut's account of the execution. The first hand account by the Frenchman resident of Manila was originally published in the French journal, *Revue des Deux Mondes* in 1877. Plauchut's account has often been called "the Filipino version" of the events that transpired in 1872. The historian John N. Schumacher, however, found the account problematic, citing inconsistencies in statements and the lack of knowledge on background events in the Philippines. Schumacher also contended that it was not clear whether Plauchut was really in the Philippines during the period of 1869 to 1873. This only led Schumacher to believe that it was highly likely that the account written by Plauchut was itself inspired and aided by at least one political prisoner, Antonio Regidor, who was imprisoned after the events of 1872. Therefore, while the "Filipino version" of the events of 1872 may contain biases towards the Filipinos, it should be read in the context of early propaganda efforts. The account published in *La Solidaridad* may indeed be "dramatic" according to Schumacher, but the motives behind the writing of such an account contributes knowledge on the workings of a propaganda efforts that preceded even Rizal's generation.

Excerpt:

Late in the night of the 15th of February 1872, a Spanish court martial found three secular priests, Jose Burgos, Mariano Gomez and Jacinto Zamora, guilty of treason as the instigators of a mutiny in the Kabite navy-yard a month before, and sentenced them to death. The judgement of the court martial was read to the priests in Fort Santiago early in the next morning and they were told it would be executed the following day... Upon hearing the sentence, Burgos broke into sobs, Zamora lost his mind and never recovered it, and only Gomez listened impassively, an old man accustomed to the thought of death.

When dawn broke on the 17th of February there were almost forty thousand of Filipinos (who came from as far as Bulakan, Pampanga, Kabite and Laguna) surrounding the four platforms where the three priests and the man whose testimony had convicted them, a former artilleryman called Saldua, would die.

The three priests followed Saldua: Burgos 'weeping like a child', Zamora with vacant eyes, and Gomez head held high, blessing the Filipinos who knelt at his feet, heads bared and praying. He was next to die. When his confessor, a Recollect friar, exhorted him loudly to accept his fate, he replied: "Father, I know that not a leaf falls to the ground but by the will of God. Since He wills that I should die here, His holy will be done."

Zamora went up the scaffold without a word and delivered his body to the executioner; his mind had already left it.

Burgos was the last, a refinement of cruelty that compelled him to watch the death of his companions. He seated himself on the iron rest and then sprang up crying: "But what crime have I committed? Is it possible that I should die like this. My God, is there no justice on earth?"

A dozen friars surrounded him and pressed him down again upon the seat of the garrote, pleading with him to die a Christian death. He obeyed but, feeling his arms tied round the fatal post, protested once again: "But I am innocent!"

"So was Jesus Christ," said one of the friars." At this Burgos resigned himself. The executioner knelt at his feet and asked his forgiveness. "I forgive you, my son. Do your duty." And it was done.

Sinibaldo de Mas, *Internal Political Condition of the Philippines* (1842). In Emma Blair and James Robertson (eds.), *The Philippine Islands, 1493-1898* (Cleveland: The Arthur H. Clark, Co., 1903-1907), vol. 52, pp. 29-90.

The Internal Conditions of the Philippines was a controversial report written by Sinibaldo de Mas, a Spanish official in the Philippines, and diplomat in Asia in the mid-nineteenth century. This secret report was part of the third volume of Mas' three-volume work on the Philippines. The first two volumes were on the historical background of the colony, the various challenges it was facing at the time, and its need for a more effective and efficient colonial administration. First published confidentially in Madrid in 1842, and then publicly the following year with a very few copies released, *The Internal Conditions* discussed Spain's three intentions with regard to the Philippines: perpetual possession, utter neglect, and emancipation. Mas focused on the first and third intentions, although he advocated the latter (emancipation) as he "cannot see what benefits [Spain could gain] from the colonies." The text below is part of Mas' discussion on the three principles that would allow Spain to control the Philippines in perpetuity. The focus here is the second principle.

Excerpt:

In order to conserve the colony, it is necessary, in my opinion, to work with reference to the spirit of the following three principles, which I shall endeavor successively to explain: 1st: It is advisable to reduce the Spanish-Filipino population¹¹ to the least possible number. 2nd: The people of color¹² must voluntarily give respect and obedience to the whites.¹³ 3rd: The general administration demands a complete reform.

...

2nd. People of color must voluntarily respect and obey the whites. In order to attain this object, it is necessary to maintain the former race in an intellectual and moral condition which will make of their numerical majority a political force less than that which resides in the second, just as a pile of straw in the balance weighs less than a gold nugget. The farmer or the goatherd does not read social contracts, or know more than what takes place in his own village. This is not the class of people who have overthrown absolutism¹⁴ in *España*, but that class who are educated in the colleges, and who know the price of guarantees, and fight for them. We must not depart from this point of view, if we are to discuss the matter sincerely. The making of liberals¹⁵ must be necessarily avoided, for in a colony the words liberal and insurgent are synonymous. The

¹¹ *Insulares* or Philippine-born Spaniards in the Philippines.

¹² Mas was referring to the native inhabitants of the colony

¹³ These were the "white" Spaniards in the colony.

¹⁴ The absolute power of a monarch

¹⁵ Educated individuals who advocated the recognition of the rights of the people

consequence of the idea will be to admit the principle that each step forward is a treading backward. It is necessary to circumscribe the education to primary schools where reading, writing, and arithmetic will be taught, continuing as at present with one school in each village, and leaving their direction to the *curas*.¹⁶ The colleges for males now existing in Manila must be closed. In English India,¹⁷ whose educational institutions and free government are of so much weight with some, there is nothing similar to this, and an Englishman who wishes to become a lawyer, a notary, a physician, or a military or civil official, has to go to England for study and graduation—I say Englishman, for the natives do not even enter into the question.

In the service of arms, they¹⁸ must not rise beyond privates or at the most corporals. It is much better to make a sergeant or officer from a Spanish farmer, even though he cannot read and write, than from the more capable native. On the contrary, the more dexterous and deserving is the latter, so much greater will be the mistake committed. Here the one who plays for gain loses. It is less dangerous and more tolerable to bestow the rank of officer on a very stupid, vicious, and cowardly fellow.

¹⁶ Priests, belonging to the religious orders, who administered the parishes

¹⁷ During that time, India was a crown colony of the British

¹⁸ Referring to the native inhabitants of the Philippines

The Staff. 1889. Our aims. In *La Solidaridad*, vol. 1: 1889, trans. Guadalupe Fores-Ganzon, 3, 5. Pasig City: Fundación Santiago.

From 1889-1895, the newspaper *La Solidaridad* served as the mouthpiece of propagandists seeking reforms for the Philippines. In its 7-year publication history, the newspaper published various works on politics, economics, literature, and society, all with the aim of introducing to a wider audience an awareness of the Spanish colony known as the Philippines and the plight of its citizens under Spanish colonial rule.

In its first issue on 15 February 1889, the first article pronounced the aims of the newspaper. As can be read from this source, the propagandists underscored the importance of defending progress and fighting all forces that countered its development. This idea would serve as the basis for all succeeding efforts made by the propagandists on behalf of the Filipinos.

Excerpt:

Our aspirations are modest, very modest. Our program, aside from being simple, is clear: to combat reaction, to stop all retrogressive steps, to extol and adopt liberal ideas, to defend progress; in a word, to be a propagandist, above all, of democratic ideas in order to make these supreme in all nations here and across the seas.

The aims, therefore, of *La Solidaridad* are described as to collect, to gather, libertarian ideas which are manifested daily in the field of politics, science, art, literature, commerce, agriculture and industry.

We shall also discuss all problems relating to the general interest of the nation and seek solutions to those problems in high-level and democratic manner.

With regard to the Philippines, since she needs the most help, not being represented in the Cortes, we shall pay particular attention to the defense of her democratic rights, the accomplishment of which is our patriotic duty.

That nation of eight million souls should not, must not be the exclusive preserve of theocracy and traditionalism.

“The Causes of the Distress of the Philippines”

Graciano Lopez Jaena, one of the leading figures of the Propaganda Movement, wrote “The Causes of the Distress of the Philippines” which was published in *España en Filipinas* in 1887. Jaena was born in Jaro Iloilo on December 18, 1856. In 1880 he left for Spain to pursue medicine but did not finish his studies as he became too involved in journalism and politics. Lopez Jaena was particularly known for impassioned speeches and articles that dealt with the problems in the Philippines. He was also known for his anti-clerical attitude as seen in some of his writings criticizing the role of the friars in the management of the affairs in the Philippines. He became La Solidaridad’s first editor in 1889.

Lopez Jaena’s “The Causes of the Distress of the Philippines” is an assessment of the problems in the Philippines. It identified the faults and shortcomings of the Spanish colonial administration particularly in education, economy, and colonial bureaucracy. The document elaborated how ineffectual the colonial government is in its duties in the colony. It also criticizes the instructions in many schools which focus more on religious education than on necessary knowledge that would help in the progress of the Philippines. Lopez Jaena also made some suggestions among which is the establishment of more free ports that would benefit the colonial economy.

The document cited here is an English translation of Lopez Jaena’s original article compiled in *Graciano Lopez Jaena: Speeches, Articles, and Letters* by the National Historical Institute (NHI).

Excerpt:

After those mentioned in the preceding article, the most notable cause of the backwardness of the Philippines is the anomalous education given to the youth in schools. They learn to read correctly and to write gracefully, but they do not learn useful things because they are not taught any. They are taught how to pray but never to work.

In all public schools Spanish grammar is conspicuous by its absence, because certain people place obstacles to teaching the Indio Spanish, the elements of physics, chemistry, geography, and agriculture, knowledge of which is certainly useful to the future of the individual and the progress of the nation; but, if all these subjects are conspicuous by their absence, on the other hand, never absent are the rosary, trisagion, the thousand and one novenas of the saints, the Virgin and the martyrs with which the tender minds of the children are nourished spiritually and viciously.

On the kind of instruction given in the Royal and Pontifical University, the seminaries and colleges we say nothing because it would be an inexhaustible subject.

The continuous change of personnel in the government is another cause of the havoc and disasters in the Philippines and in the colonies in general. Such a swift change is only comparable to the locusts which, after devastating the fields, are replaced in swift and vertiginous succession. If to this is added the incompetence of the majority of the government personnel, it becomes evident that from progression to progression, the country in a short time reaches the apogee of her ruin.

The fatal omission of natives from the government positions of high or average importance is its corollary: the lack of any improvement in the Philippines, the towns remaining stagnant and backward. Since some of those who give orders, who govern and administer are inept and insecure in their posts, it matters little to them whether the country improves and advances or not.

We are not unaware that there exist royal decrees on the filling of the government positions with natives, but the truth is these are not followed and the law and everything else about this matter are a dead letter.

Another cause of the ruinous condition of the Archipelago is the Mint in Manila which turns out gold and silver coins that enrich China and the British colonies rather than the Philippines. The Chinese and the British export our gold and silver, the first to their country and the other to her colonies, paying "hard premium" in Mexican silver, common in the Islands, so that it has become very difficult to obtain in Manila four-peso gold coin.

The abolition of the existing differential duties, freedom of commerce, freedom of association, freedom of the press through which the Filipino may study or learn about the progress of all the branches of industry, commerce and agriculture for their own benefit and for that of their country, as well as how to convert China and Japan into markets for our products through the negotiation of commercial treaties with them, are the supreme remedies to reactivate and restore to life the already comatose Philippine commerce.

With regard to the Chinese, inasmuch as they have already joined the convert of nations, the powers ought to compel them to mint their own coins and adopt their own monetary system, for it is not fair that they should take advantage of the specie of every country. With their present commercial methods, it is impossible to transact business and exchange with them.

Likewise, it is urgent to establish free ports for the benefit of the natives of the country, inasmuch as nature has created these ports for the use of the people who live in them. To go against nature is to violate natural law; it is to infringe on the very work of God. Human justice, policy, and government should act in conformity with, never against the laws of nature.

Álbum de Filipinas, ca. 1870, Biblioteca Nacional de España

The album is a collection of late-nineteenth-century photographs in the Philippines housed at the National Library of Spain (Biblioteca Nacional de España), Madrid, Spain. It consists of 17 portraits and 43 landscape photographs that offer a rich source of pictorial information on the socio-cultural, economic, and urban history of the last decades of Spanish rule in Manila and its nearby areas.^{IS}

The source provides a visual reconstruction and representation of the many facets of the Philippine colonial life. The different socio-economic and ethnic classes of colonial Philippines were illustrated through several portraits of the Spanish population, Spanish and Chinese mestizos, natives, other European inhabitants of Manila, as well as the Negritos in the province of Pampanga. Women history, social history, and sartorial studies could be gleaned from these visual sources. Also, the album provides supplementary pictorial sources on the Philippines' economic history in the late nineteenth century through some photos of the bustling port of Manila, the commercial activities along the Pasig river, the tobacco factory, etc. Moreover, it excellently depicts the urban built environment of the colonial capital and the dwellings found at the Pasig River's right and left bank. Manila's colonial modernity can be interrogated through the innovative structures and spaces introduced in Manila during the late nineteenth-century. The catalogue shows the modernization project of the city's port; rehabilitation of the Pasig River and surrounding estuaries; improvement of the inhabitants' mobility and communication through new bridges and paved and widened roads; and the city transformation with the introduction of *paseos* and plazas for the city's embellishment. Finally, the album can aid in discussing the Philippines' history of disasters through photos depicting some of the destruction in the capital caused by the 1863 earthquake and the reconstruction efforts on some of the primary colonial edifices and churches in Manila.